

Nat Turner's rebellion

The bloodiest American slave rebellion took place in 1831. It was led by Nat Turner, born a slave in 1800 in Southampton, Virginia. By his twenties, he had become a spiritual leader among his fellow slaves and was persuaded by a series of visions that God was preparing him for a great battle. A solar eclipse early in 1831 was, for Turner, the sign that he should plan a rebellion, and on August 21, he set out with six other slaves to attack plantations. As they moved from farm to farm, killing at least 55 white people, the rebels grew to around 75 strong. Their goal was to reach the town of Jerusalem, but they were soon broken up by 3,000 state militia.

Turner went on the run but was captured and hanged, and 55 of his fellow rebels were executed. White mobs soon went on a killing spree among slaves but received no punishment. Afterward, both Virginia and neighboring North Carolina imposed even harsher slave codes.



After hiding in woods for 6 weeks, slave leader Nat Turner was captured on October 30, 1831, by farmer Benjamin Phipps and executed on November 11.



A 19th-century woodcut shows African American slaves picking cotton. Huge demand for the fiber from textile manufacturers fueled the high number of plantation slaves.

Keeping control over slaves and their personal relationships also helped maintain racial purity. Male owners often took sexual advantage of their female slaves, but the codes made it plain that the responsibility for any resulting offspring rested not with the father, as established in English common law, but with the mother. A Virginia slave code of 1662 stated that “all children born in this country shall be held bond or free only according to the condition of the mother.” This committed any child of a slave mother, including one born mixed race, to a life of slavery.

Slave codes also stamped out all prospects of settled relationships between races. In 1664, Maryland passed the first “anti-amalgamation” law to prevent marriage between races, and other American colonies soon followed suit.

Internal slavery

In 1807, President Thomas Jefferson signed the legislation that officially ended the US slave trade. But that did not mean an end to slavery

or even the slave codes. As the external slave trade dried up, the slave market within the US intensified, alongside a boom in the growing of cotton. Slave women were encouraged to “breed,” with girls as young as 13 being cajoled into motherhood to provide more slave children.

By the time the Civil War broke out in 1861, there were still 15 slave states in the US, all of which had slave codes. Even when the war officially ended slavery in 1865, “black codes” were developed in Southern states to limit the freedoms of former slaves and keep them on low wages. It took another century, and the passing of the 1964 Civil Rights Act, for the descendants of African American slaves to finally begin to enjoy the same legal rights as the descendants of white slave owners. ■